

MATH 345 Skeleton Notes

Unit 2: Anatomy of a linear map

Section 2.5: Inverses and determinants

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Matrix invertibility and linear systems

In this section we finish the square-matrix version of the Unit 2 story. A square matrix is invertible exactly when it “does not forget any nonzero input direction” and “every output is reached once”. The inverse matrix gives the inverse map when it exists. The determinant, a fundamental quantity in linear algebra that we only briefly discuss in this course, gives a single-number test for invertibility.

Definition: Invertibility of Matrices

An $n \times n$ matrix A is called nonsingular, or invertible, if there exists an $n \times n$ matrix B such that $AB = BA = I_n$. Such a B is called the inverse of A . If no such B exists, A is called singular or noninvertible.

Note

The inverse of a matrix mimics the reciprocal of a real number.

Activity: Testing whether two matrices are inverses (U2-LO5)

Let

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 1 & 4 \end{bmatrix} \quad \text{and} \quad B = \begin{bmatrix} 4 & -3 \\ -1 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Compute both AB and BA , and make a conclusion using the language of inverses.

Fact

The inverse of a matrix, if it exists, is unique. Therefore, we can write A^{-1} for the inverse of A .

Fact

For $n \times n$ matrices A and B , if $AB = I_n$, then $BA = I_n$.

Activity: Testing a matrix for invertibility (U2-LO5)

Does $A = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$ have an inverse?

Theorem

If both A and B are nonsingular $n \times n$ matrices, then the matrix AB is

nonsingular and its inverse is $(AB)^{-1} = B^{-1}A^{-1}$.

Why is this true?

It suffices to calculate that $(AB)(B^{-1}A^{-1}) = I_n$ and $(B^{-1}A^{-1})(AB) = I_n$.
Firstly,

$$(AB)(B^{-1}A^{-1}) = A(BB^{-1})A^{-1} = AI_nA^{-1} = AA^{-1} = I_n.$$

Similarly,

$$(B^{-1}A^{-1})(AB) = B^{-1}(A^{-1}A)B = B^{-1}I_nB = B^{-1}B = I_n.$$

Fact: Follow Up Facts About Invertibility

- If $A_1, A_2, \dots, A_k$ are $n \times n$ invertible / nonsingular matrices, then $A_1A_2 \cdots A_k$ is invertible / nonsingular and

$$(A_1A_2 \cdots A_k)^{-1} = A_k^{-1} \cdots A_2^{-1}A_1^{-1}.$$

- If A is invertible/nonsingular, then A^{-1} is invertible/nonsingular and

$$(A^{-1})^{-1} = A.$$

- If A is invertible/nonsingular, then A^T is invertible/nonsingular and

$$(A^{-1})^T = (A^T)^{-1}.$$

Let $T = T_A : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ be a matrix transformation induced by the $n \times n$ matrix A . What does invertibility imply about the geometry of the transformation T_A ?

Consider $T' = T_{A^{-1}}$. What happens when we compose them?

Activity: Composing a map and its inverse (U2-L05)

Compute the composition of T and T' in both orders.

Definition

Given a matrix transformation $T : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$, if there exists a transformation $S : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ such that $S(T(\mathbf{x})) = T(S(\mathbf{x})) = \mathbf{x}$ for all $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, we say that T has an inverse.

Theorem

Let $T : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ denote the matrix transformation induced by an $n \times n$ matrix A . Then:

1. A is invertible if and only if T has an inverse.
2. In this case, T has exactly one inverse (which we denote as T^{-1}), and $T^{-1} : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ is the transformation induced by the matrix A^{-1} .

In other words, $(T_A)^{-1} = T_{A^{-1}}$.

T and T^{-1} ‘reverse’ or ‘undo’ the action of each other.

Activity: Reversing a reflection (U2-L05)

Consider $T : \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ given by reflection across the x -axis. Find the matrix representing this transformation, and find the inverse.

Theorem

The 2×2 matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$$

is invertible if and only if $ad - bc \neq 0$, in which case

$$A^{-1} = \frac{1}{ad - bc} \begin{bmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{bmatrix}$$

We define the **determinant** of the matrix A to be the quantity $\det(A) = ad - bc$. Thus the matrix A is invertible if and only if its determinant is nonzero.

For now, $\det(A) = ad - bc$ is only the determinant of a 2×2 matrix. We will define determinants for larger square matrices later in this section.

Activity: Reading determinant checks in code (U2-LO3, U2-LO5, U2-LO7)

The following code computes determinants of two 2×2 matrices.

```
import numpy as np

A = np.array([
    [1., 1.],
    [0., 1.],
])

B = np.array([
    [1., 0.],
    [0., 0.],
])

detA = float(np.linalg.det(A))
detB = float(np.linalg.det(B))

detA, detB
```

Output:

```
(1.0, 0.0)
```

**Activity: Reading determinant checks in code (U2-LO3, U2-LO5, U2-LO7)
(continued)**

1. Which matrix is invertible?
2. Which matrix forgets a nonzero input direction?
3. How does the determinant tell you?

Activity: Checking invertibility and finding inverses (U2-LO5)

Find the inverse of each matrix, if possible.

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} -2 & -3 \\ 4 & 6 \end{bmatrix}$$

Activity: Checking invertibility and finding inverses (U2-LO5)

Find the inverse of each matrix, if possible.

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 6 \\ 2 & 3 \end{bmatrix}$$

If A is an $n \times n$ matrix, then the linear system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is a system of n equations in n unknowns. Suppose A is nonsingular. How can we use A^{-1} to solve the system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$?

Activity: Solving a system with an inverse (U2-LO5)

Solve the system using the inverse of A .

Consequences:

- When A^{-1} exists, then $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has a unique solution.
- If A is invertible/nonsingular, then the *only* solution to the homogeneous system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ is $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$.
- Put differently, an invertible square matrix forgets no nonzero input direction.

Activity: One inverse, several right-hand sides (U2-L05)

Suppose that

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{b} = \begin{bmatrix} 4 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{c} = \begin{bmatrix} 3 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Use this information to calculate the solution to the following systems:

$$A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$$

Activity: One inverse, several right-hand sides (U2-LO5)

Suppose that

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{b} = \begin{bmatrix} 4 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{c} = \begin{bmatrix} 3 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Use this information to calculate the solution to the following systems:

$$A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{c}$$

Activity: One inverse, several right-hand sides (U2-LO5)

Suppose that

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{b} = \begin{bmatrix} 4 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{c} = \begin{bmatrix} 3 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Use this information to calculate the solution to the following systems:

$$A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$$

Activity: A coordinate map and invertibility (U2-LO5)

Consider the transformation $P : \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ defined by

$$P \left(\begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \end{bmatrix} \right) = \begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Is P a matrix transformation? If so, find the matrix A corresponding to P .

Activity: A coordinate map and invertibility (U2-LO5)

Consider the transformation $P : \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ defined by

Activity: A coordinate map and invertibility (U2-LO5) (continued)

$$P\left(\begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \end{bmatrix}\right) = \begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Is P an invertible transformation?

Consider vectors $\mathbf{c}_1, \dots, \mathbf{c}_n$ in $\mathbb{R}^m$, and let A be the $m \times n$ matrix whose columns are the vectors $\mathbf{c}_1, \dots, \mathbf{c}_n$. Recall that $\{\mathbf{c}_1, \dots, \mathbf{c}_n\}$ are linearly independent precisely when the equation $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has *only* the *trivial* solution (see Linear Independence and the uniqueness theorem, the theorem). By Spanning and solvability, $\text{span}\{\mathbf{c}_1, \dots, \mathbf{c}_n\} = \mathbb{R}^m$ exactly when $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has a solution for all $\mathbf{b}$ in $\mathbb{R}^m$.

Theorem: Invertibility Criteria

Let A be an $n \times n$ matrix. The following are equivalent:

1. A is nonsingular/invertible.
2. The columns of A are linearly independent.
3. The columns of A span $\mathbb{R}^n$.
4. The rows of A are linearly independent.
5. The rows of A span $\mathbb{R}^n$.
6. $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the trivial solution.
7. A is row equivalent to I_n .

8. The linear system $Ax = b$ has a unique solution for every $n \times 1$ matrix b .
9. The rank of A is n .

Activity: Testing dependence using a matrix (U2-L04)

Let $S = \{v_1, v_2, v_3\}$, where

$$v_1 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 2 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix} \quad v_2 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ -1 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix} \quad v_3 = \begin{bmatrix} 3 \\ 0 \\ -5 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Is S linearly dependent?

General Determinants

In this section we consider square $n \times n$ matrices. Our *goal* is to find a number, called the *determinant* that we can calculate for any matrix, which tells us whether or not the matrix is invertible.

We use the 2×2 determinant from the theorem to define the 3×3 determinant. The idea is recursive: a 3×3 determinant is built from 2×2 determinants. Later, an $n \times n$ determinant will be built from $(n - 1) \times (n - 1)$ determinants.

Definition: Minors of a 3×3 matrix

Let A be a 3×3 matrix. The (i, j) -th minor of A , denoted

$$\text{minor}(A)_{ij},$$

is the determinant of the 2×2 matrix obtained from A by deleting row i and column j .

Activity: Computing matrix minors (U2-L07)

Suppose

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Calculate $\text{minor}(A)_{11}$.

Activity: Computing matrix minors (U2-L07)

Suppose

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Calculate $\text{minor}(A)_{23}$.

Definition: Cofactors of a 3×3 matrix

Let A be a 3×3 matrix. The (i, j) -cofactor of A , denoted

$$\text{cof}(A)_{ij},$$

is

$$\text{cof}(A)_{ij} = (-1)^{i+j} \text{minor}(A)_{ij}.$$

Activity: Computing cofactors (U2-L07)

Define

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

Compute $\text{cof}(A)_{11}$.

Activity: Computing cofactors (U2-LO7)

Define

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

Compute $\text{cof}(A)_{23}$.

Definition: Determinant of a 3×3 matrix

Let $A = [a_{ij}]$ be a 3×3 matrix. The **determinant** of A , denoted $\det(A)$, is defined by expansion along the first row:

$$\det(A) = a_{11} \text{cof}(A)_{11} + a_{12} \text{cof}(A)_{12} + a_{13} \text{cof}(A)_{13}.$$

This process is called **cofactor expansion**.

Fact

For a 3×3 matrix, cofactor expansion along any row or any column gives

the same determinant.

Activity: Comparing row and column expansions (U2-L07)

Let

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Find the determinant of A by expanding along row 1.

Activity: Comparing row and column expansions (U2-L07)

Let

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Find the determinant of A by expanding along column 2.

Note

To track the sign $(-1)^{i+j}$ when computing cofactors, it may be helpful to view the matrix as a checkerboard as below:

$$\begin{bmatrix} + & - & + \\ - & + & - \\ + & - & + \end{bmatrix}$$

The sign in the i th row and j th position will be the sign of $(-1)^{i+j}$.

Note

Since any row or column gives the same determinant, choose a row or column with many zeros when possible.

Activity: Choosing a determinant expansion (U2-L07)

Compute the determinant of the following matrices:

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & -5 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ -2 & -4 & 7 \end{bmatrix}$$

Activity: Choosing a determinant expansion (U2-L07)

Compute the determinant of the following matrices:

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & \pi & 200 \\ 0 & 0.03 & 4 \\ 0 & 19 & -3584 \end{bmatrix}$$

Note

Whenever a row or column of a matrix only has zeros as entries, expanding along that row shows that the determinant of the matrix is always zero, so no cofactor computations are required.

Now that 3×3 determinants have been defined, we can define larger determinants recursively. For a 4×4 matrix, each minor determinant is a 3×3 determinant. For a 5×5 matrix, each minor determinant is a 4×4 determinant, and so on.

Definition: Determinant of a general square matrix

Let $A = [a_{ij}]$ be an $n \times n$ matrix with $n \geq 4$. Assume determinants have already been defined for $(n - 1) \times (n - 1)$ matrices.

The (i, j) -th minor of A , denoted

$$\text{minor}(A)_{ij},$$

is the determinant of the $(n - 1) \times (n - 1)$ matrix obtained from A by deleting row i and column j .

The (i, j) -cofactor of A is

$$\text{cof}(A)_{ij} = (-1)^{i+j} \text{minor}(A)_{ij}.$$

The determinant of A is defined by expansion along the first row:

$$\det(A) = \sum_{j=1}^n a_{1j} \operatorname{cof}(A)_{1j}.$$

Fact

For an $n \times n$ matrix, cofactor expansion along any row or any column gives the same determinant:

$$\det(A) = \sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij} \operatorname{cof}(A)_{ij}$$

for any fixed row i , and

$$\det(A) = \sum_{i=1}^n a_{ij} \operatorname{cof}(A)_{ij}$$

for any fixed column j .

Activity: A four-by-four determinant (U2-L07)

Calculate the determinant of the matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 \\ 5 & 4 & 2 & 3 \\ 1 & 3 & 4 & 5 \\ 3 & 4 & 3 & 2 \end{bmatrix}$$

Activity: The determinant of a triangular matrix (U2-L07)

Compute $\det(A)$, where

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 2 & 3 & 4 \\ 0 & 4 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 5 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & -1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Recall Main diagonal.

Definition: Triangular and Diagonal Matrices

An $n \times n$ matrix $A = [a_{ij}]$ is called **upper triangular** if $a_{ij} = 0$

for $i > j$, and **lower triangular** if $a_{ij} = 0$ for $i < j$. A matrix is

diagonal if it is both upper triangular and lower triangular, i.e., if $a_{ij} = 0$ for $i \neq j$. We denote the $n \times n$ diagonal matrix with entries $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n$ on the diagonal by $\text{diag}(\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n)$.

Theorem

If $A = [a_{ij}]$ is a upper or lower triangular matrix, then $\det(A) = a_{11} \cdots a_{nn}$. That is, the determinant of a triangular matrix is the product of entries in the *main diagonal*.

Why is this true?

A generalization of the argument used to calculate The determinant of a triangular matrix (U2-LO7), i.e., expanding the determinant in cofactors

along the first column iteratively.

Theorem

If a row or column of a matrix A consists entirely of zeros, then $\det(A) = 0$.

Why is this true?

A generalization of the argument used to calculate the determinant in the activity.

Theorem

If a matrix B is obtained from a matrix A by swapping two rows or two columns, then $\det(B) = -\det(A)$.

Activity: Row swaps and determinants (U2-LO7)

Check directly that the theorem is true when A and B are 2×2 matrices.

Why is this true?

If

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$$

and

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} c & d \\ a & b \end{bmatrix},$$

then $\det(A) = ad - bc$ and $\det(B) = cb - ad = -(ad - bc) = -\det(A)$.

Theorem

If two rows (or columns) of A are equal to one another, then $\det(A) = 0$.

Why is this true?

Let B be obtained by swapping the two identical rows (or columns) of A . Then $A = B$, and the theorem implies that $\det(A) = -\det(B) = -\det(A)$. Therefore $2\det(A) = 0$, and thus that $\det(A) = 0$.

Theorem

If B is obtained from A by multiplying each entry in a row or column of A by a quantity k , then $\det(B) = k\det(A)$.

Why is this true?

Suppose that B is obtained from A by multiplying each entry of row i by k . Consider a cofactor expansion along row i of B . Then

$$\begin{aligned}\det(B) &= ka_{i1}\text{cof}(B)_{i1} + ka_{i2}\text{cof}(B)_{i2} + \cdots + ka_{in}\text{cof}(B)_{in} \\ &= k[a_{i1}\text{cof}(A)_{i1} + \cdots + a_{in}\text{cof}(A)_{in}] \\ &= k\det(A).\end{aligned}$$

Fact

If A is a $n \times n$ matrix, then $\det(kA) = k^n \det(A)$.

Theorem

If B is obtained by adding k times the i th row of A to the j th row, for $i \neq j$, which is a row operation which we denote by $R_j \rightarrow R_j + kR_i$, then $\det(B) = \det(A)$.

We can check the theorem in the 2×2 case. If

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$$

and

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c + ka & d + kb \end{bmatrix},$$

then

$$\det(A) = ad - bc$$

and

$$\begin{aligned}\det(B) &= a(d + kb) - b(c + ka) \\ &= ad + kab - bc - kab \\ &= ad - bc = \det(A).\end{aligned}$$

Theorem: How row operations affect the determinant

Here is a summary of how the elementary row operations, when applied to a matrix, affect the determinant:

- $R_i \rightarrow kR_i$ multiplies the determinant by k .
- $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$ multiplies the determinant by -1 .
- $R_j \rightarrow R_j + kR_i$ leaves the determinant unchanged.

Activity: Tracking determinants through row operations (U2-L07)

Suppose a matrix B is obtained from a matrix A by applying the following row operations:

- $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$
- $R_4 \rightarrow 4R_4$
- $R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + 3R_2$

If $\det(A) = 8$, what is the determinant of B .

Activity: Evaluating a three-by-three determinant (U2-L07)

Compute the determinant of the matrix

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ -1 & 3 & 3 \\ 0 & 15 & 12 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Theorem

If A and B are $n \times n$ matrices, then $\det(AB) = \det(A) \det(B)$.

Activity: Determinants of matrices and their products (U2-LO7)

Let

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ -2 & 7 \end{bmatrix} \quad B = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 4 \end{bmatrix} \quad C = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 4 \\ 0 & 2 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Compute the determinant of A , B , and C .

Activity: Determinants of matrices and their products (U2-LO7)

Let

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ -2 & 7 \end{bmatrix} \quad B = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 4 \end{bmatrix} \quad C = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 4 \\ 0 & 2 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Compute the determinant of AC and BC .

Theorem

If A is a $n \times n$ matrix, then A is *nonsingular* if and only if $\det(A) \neq 0$. In this case $\det(A^{-1}) = 1/\det(A)$.

Why is this true?

We prove only one direction of the theorem, that if A is nonsingular then $\det(A) \neq 0$ and $\det(A^{-1}) = 1/\det(A)$. Suppose that A is non-singular. Then $AA^{-1} = I$. Taking determinants of both sides, and using that I is diagonal, so that $\det(I) = 1$, we see that

$$1 = \det(I) = \det(AA^{-1}) = \det(A) \det(A^{-1}).$$

Thus $\det(A) \neq 0$ (since otherwise the right hand side of this equation would be zero), and rearranging gives $\det(A^{-1}) = 1/\det(A)$.

Theorem

If A is a square matrix, then $\det(A) = \det(A^T)$.

Definition: Orthogonal Matrices

A square matrix A is orthogonal if $A^T = A^{-1}$.

Activity: Determinants of orthogonal matrices (U2-LO7)

If A is an orthogonal matrix, what are the possible values of $\det(A)$?

Optional: Calculating Inverses

For a given $n \times n$ matrix A , if we are looking for an inverse for A (call this matrix X), we must have $AX = I_n$. We are solving n linear systems simultaneously:

Activity: Equations for the columns of an inverse (U2-LO1, U2-LO5)

Describe the system of linear equations for finding the inverse.

Since, to solve each system, we wish to reduce the matrix A down to its RREF each time, we can combine all the systems into one big augmented matrix:

Activity: Setting up an inverse calculation (U2-LO1, U2-LO5)

Write the augmented matrix for finding the inverse.

It follows from the theorem that if $[A \mid I_n]$ is row reducible to $[B \mid C]$, then $BX = C$. In particular, if we can row reduce $[A \mid I_n]$ to $[I_n \mid C]$, then it follows that $X = C$. Gaussian elimination (The Gaussian Elimination Algorithm) will reduce a given matrix to this form, provided that an inverse exists.

Algorithm: Algorithm for Computing A^{-1}

1. Set up the augmented matrix $[A \mid I_n]$.
2. Apply elementary row operations to $[A \mid I_n]$ to reduce it to $[I_n \mid A^{-1}]$.

If A is an $n \times n$ matrix, either A can be reduced to I_n by elementary row operations or it cannot. In the first case, the algorithm produces A^{-1} ; in the second case, A^{-1} does not exist.

Activity: Computing an inverse by row reduction (U2-LO5)

Find A^{-1} where $A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 & 4 \\ 2 & 3 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$.

